point, Berlin became the main route by which East Germans fled West via eighty-one sector crossing points. More than 15,500 disenchanted souls of all creeds and political views (including 2,000 farmers) fled to West Berlin during October, marking the highest number of any post-war month.

This drain on manpower worsened during the first week of December when 600 farmers laden with personal baggage took flight, leaving large areas of land lying idle for want of labour.9 Few knew where they were going, or for how long. The vast majority would never return. Officials in the Western sector said refugees were fleeing ‘iron discipline, grey routine, blind purges and the fear of something worse happening’. Some left to avoid army call-up, others because their property was confiscated, or they were persecuted as Christians. In the latter area, Honecker was particularly active. Already by 1951, he had managed to contain church youth work by having 3,000 boys and girls expelled from school for being members of the ‘Junge Gemeinde’, the Protestant Church parish youth group. Under his aegis, an ongoing campaign of demonising Christians would continue throughout 1952. And as if that wasn’t bad enough, the SED recommended the abolition of workers’ Christmas bonuses, describing the traditional system as ‘a disgraceful hangover from the capitalistic era’. For many East Germans, Ulbricht’s socialist paradise was worse than living in Nazi Germany.